JUSTICE BY THE BULLET

39 accused have been killed & 123 injured in Assam in police firing over last one year

Category	Killed in police firing	Injured in police firing
Cattle smuggler	1	11
Drugs peddler	4	48
Extremists	13	4
Linkmen	0	1
Criminals	18	56
Eviction protesters	2	2
Kingpin	0	1
Coal mafia	1	0

Source: Assam Police, Between May 10, 2021, and May 1, 2022

ANI



RULE OF KHAKI
(Left) Police take Jignesh Mevani to Kokrajhar police station; (above) Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma inspects the passing out parade of police cadets

September 2021, 453 land brokers were arrested during a single-day raid.

The pattern of "shootouts"/ encounters started with an incident of rape. On June 12, 2021, two teenage sisters who had been raped and killed were found hanging from a tree in Singimari village in Kokrajhar district, some 240 km west of Guwahati. Sarma reached the victim's home the very next day and asked the police team to apprehend the perpetrators within 24 hours. Three accused were arrested on June 14 and one of them was grievously injured while allegedly trying to flee police custody.

Since then, as one history-sheeter or the other was felled in serial incidents of police firing, a massive public approbation gradually built up in Assam for this rough-and-ready mode of justice. By November last year, when a history-sheeter killed a student leader in broad daylight in Jorhat, TV anchors were openly demanding that the accused be given the "encounter treatment". Within 24 hours of his arrest, he was found dead, this time hit by a police vehicle as he allegedly tried to flee. There was an indirect acceptance, too, of the "accidental death" as part of an official mechanism for retributive justice. Within the hour, G.P. Singh, special DGP of law and order, tweeted: "For every action, there is an equal and opposite reaction—Newton's third law." Sarma issued a solidarity tweet: "Assam will be free of crime and criminal, come what may."

Public jubilation over this "most deserved encounter" turned into red-hot anger against the police in January when, in Nagaon, the anti-narcotic team formed by the then SP Anand Mishra shot and injured a student leader for alleged involvement in drug peddling. Locals and family members cried foul, claiming a frame-up, following which the state government initiated a probe. Based on its recommendations, Mishra was transferred and the policemen involved in the incident suspended.

THE MEVANI AFFAIR ONLY HIGHLIGHTED A 'PROACTIVIST' STREAK VISIBLE IN ASSAM POLICE FOR A YEAR

The Mevani affair has now added to the list of controversies the Assam Police has found itself embroiled in. Arup Dey, a BJP functionary in Assam, filed an FIR against the Gujarat MLA on April 18 for an alleged "offensive" tweet about Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Mevani was arrested by Kokrajhar Police in Gujarat's Palanpur town on the night of April 20. The Kokrajhar court granted him bail on April 25, but he was rearrested by Barpeta police after a lady police officer claimed Mevani had allegedly "used slang words" and had "physically pushed her". Whichever way it winds down, the episode only framed a trend that had been visible for a year. ■